

Return governance and diplomacy between Türkiye and Afghanistan

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Funding information

European Commission

Abstract

There is growing scholarly and policy interest in understanding how destination and transit countries develop return migration policies and collaborate with origin countries. This study investigates the dynamics, drivers and outcomes of the collaborative process between Turkish and Afghan authorities in governing the return of Afghan migrants. Drawing on the concept of return diplomacy, derived from the broader framework of migration diplomacy—which explores the interplay between cross-border mobility and foreign policymaking—we analyse the bilateral talks and arrangements shaping these returns. Our examination of official documents, news sources, interviews and engagements with key informants reveals that authorities on both sides get involved in return diplomacy by leveraging historical and religious networks, as well as humanitarian diplomacy instruments. The drivers of this process are rooted in the domestic priorities of the Turkish government to manage return flows and the expectations of Afghan authorities and the Taliban for international legitimacy and aid through cooperation. The collaboration reflects a blend of formal and informal relations and practices. The outcomes, however, highlight significant opacity in bilateral negotiations and arrangements. These efforts lack a structured readmission framework and have resulted in

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record-high coerced returns of Afghan migrants (officially 42,498 in 2022) with minimal monitoring. While not fully representative, this case study provides valuable insights for enhancing theories of migration diplomacy and return governance by underscoring the utility of a decentred approach and emphasis on South-to-South contexts.

INTRODUCTION

There is a growing emphasis on advocating international cooperation as a potential solution to the complex migration governance challenges. The Global Compact on Refugees (GCR, 2018) highlights the need for cooperation of the international community with countries of origin for the safe and dignified return¹ of refugees, emphasizing voluntary repatriation and addressing the root causes of displacement. Similarly, the New Pact on Migration and Asylum (2024) by the European Commission aims to integrate migration into international partnerships, focusing on collaboration with countries of origin about return and readmission processes, as well as development cooperation. European countries especially deploy various diplomatic channels to govern the returns, repatriation, deportation and removal of² so-called unwanted migrants. Many of these migrants can be identified as “irregularized humanitarian migrants,” who left their country of citizenship in hopes of finding protection abroad but do not, or no longer, hold a permanent legal status’ (van Houte et al., 2023, p. 315). To compel the return of these migrants, who are referred to as ‘irregular’, ‘unauthorized’ or ‘illegal’ in national legislations and policies, various types of negotiations take place between destination and transit/origin countries, as exemplified by the recent EU–Tunisia Memorandum of Understanding (2023), the Italy–Albania deal (2023) and the Turkey–EU deal of 2016. The politicization of migration in domestic and international realms appears as a global phenomenon. Likewise, the emphasis on cooperation to manage migration and facilitate returns is increasingly shaping bilateral relations beyond Europe. A prominent example is the coordination between Türkiye and Afghanistan on return processes, which raises critical questions about the drivers, dynamics and outcomes of such collaboration.

Türkiye's migration agency, the Presidency of Migration Management (PMM), reported that the country deported over 109,000 individuals classified officially as ‘irregular’ migrants in 2022. Turkish officials express pride in these ‘record’ numbers, noting that ‘while the EU countries’ deportation rate is around ten per cent... Our rate is around 70 per cent’ (Göçgov X, 2023). More than half of those deported were Afghans—66,534 in total, 44,433 of them via 234 charter flights and 22,101 on scheduled flights (PMM, 2022). Only 2259 migrants were returned with the assistance of the International Organization of Migration (IOM).³ Other Afghans were returned under special arrangements with the Turkish and Taliban authorities. In 2023, PMM reported that some 10,260 individuals classified as ‘irregular migrants’ were deported (Göçgov, 2023). One point of clarity about Afghans’ status in Türkiye is needed here. Afghans are eligible for International Protection Status (IPS) as defined in the Turkish Law of Foreigners and International Protection (LFIP, 2013). However, access to IPS remains limited in practice, and even when granted, it is generally temporary, with resettlement processes often extending for decades. In 2023, the number of Afghan asylum seekers under IPS was 13,068 (Göçgov IPS, 2024). A significant portion of the Afghan population in Türkiye remains undocumented and unregistered, primarily categorized and counted as ‘irregular migrants,’ by Turkish authorities. Apprehension figures have been substantial, with 201,437 cases in 2018 and 68,687 in 2023 (Göçgov Irregular, 2024). During or after irregular border crossings, over 21,000 Afghans were apprehended between January and April of 2024 (Göçgov, 2024). The apprehended Afghans, who are often given removal decisions and kept in removal (detention) centres, are potential targets of Türkiye's return policy and the subject of bilateral return diplomacy with Afghanistan.

Unlike the formal approach of governing returns through signed readmission agreements, Türkiye and Afghanistan lack a formal bilateral readmission arrangement or a memorandum of understanding. Instead, the process relies on diplomatic engagements, informal visits and discussions among bureaucrats, elites and group representatives. These negotiations, which often address the issue of returns without culminating in formal agreements, can be characterized as return diplomacy—a nexus where cross-border mobility and foreign policy converge.

Return diplomacy facilitates flexible bilateral arrangements through informal mechanisms such as soft instruments and verbal agreements to 'sort affairs'. These include processes like identifying individuals, issuing international travel documents in coordination with Afghan public authorities, and managing logistics such as charter flights. Such engagements enable Turkish authorities to deport Afghans and Afghan authorities to readmit their citizens. As a result, the outcomes of these bilateral efforts materialize in ambiguous, adaptable and often temporary formats. Despite their informal nature, these arrangements yield substantial impacts, as thousands of Afghan migrants have been returned in recent years. Published reports and news underscore this dynamic, noting that 'Afghanistan is a country that works closely with Turkey in deportation processes' (Karadağ, 2021, p. 38).

During the return process, Afghan migrants encounter varying degrees of coercion. These include pushbacks at border crossings between Iran and Türkiye, restricted access to legal aid and asylum applications, prolonged detentions in removal centres and deceptive practices in obtaining signatures on voluntary return documents upon their arrival (Sahin-Mencutek, 2022; Sahin-Mencutek & Triandafyllidou, 2025; HRW, 2022; Karadağ, 2021). While the full extent of coercion remains unclear and insufficiently studied, these practices collectively align with the concept of coerced returns, as explored in this article.

This explanatory study explores the dynamics, drivers and outcomes of return diplomacy between Türkiye and Afghanistan regarding the governance of the coerced returns of Afghans. To conduct a comprehensive analysis, the study addresses several key questions. The *first* question scrutinizes the drivers of return diplomacy. What factors drive this intensified emphasis on returns? How do historical ties, cultural connections and potential economic incentives influence the Taliban government's approach to accepting returns? In what ways does the power asymmetry between Türkiye and Afghanistan shape the negotiation process? The *second* question examines the dynamics of return procedures for Afghan migrants in Türkiye and how these policies are implemented and executed. For example, at what levels has the Turkish government engaged in dialogue with the interim Taliban government in Afghanistan? How have formal and informal arrangements between Türkiye and the Taliban emerged and been maintained? The *final* question investigates the outcomes generated by return diplomacy, in other words, its consequences.

To address the questions analytically, we need to establish a conceptual foundation. The concept of migration diplomacy provides a valuable analytical starting point for examining the instrumentalization of migrants and refugees as leverage in diplomacy (Tsourapas, 2018). The concept highlights two key aspects: (1) the use of migration to achieve foreign policy goals such as gaining credibility, deterrence and coercive power, and (2) the use of foreign policy tools and procedures to manage cross-border population mobility (Tsourapas, 2017). Migration diplomacy plays a crucial role in the return and readmission processes, as these require coordination between the authorities of both the returning and receiving states. To further refine this analysis, we introduce the concept of return diplomacy, which can be seen as a subcategory of the migration diplomacy framework and encompasses international politics surrounding all types of migration. Return diplomacy is more specific and refers to the strategic use of negotiations, bargaining between and a mix of diplomatic instruments to govern the return of migrants, particularly those considered irregular or unauthorized.

Return diplomacy entails destination countries employing diplomatic strategies to establish flexible arrangements for expediting returns to transit, origin or other accepting countries. These arrangements rely on a blend of formal and informal tools, methods and relationships to achieve their objectives. A notable feature of this process is issue linkages, where cooperation on return policies is intertwined with broader foreign policy goals, particularly efforts to enhance bilateral relations. For example, origin and transit countries often agree to readmission

requests as a means to secure financial aid, political leverage or symbolic gains that align with their national interests (Bürgin, 2012; Laube, 2019; Wolff, 2014). Our study also incorporates theoretical discussions on the grey zones in migration policymaking, suggesting that the entanglement of formality and informality is inherent in migration diplomacy and potentially shapes bilateral negotiations on returns.

Based on empirical evidence drawn from official documents, news reports and interviews with key informants, we contend that the growing emphasis on cooperation and coordination in return practices reflects the expanding scope of return diplomacy between Türkiye and Afghanistan. An analysis of their bilateral relations indicates a mutual interest in leveraging diplomatic tools and processes to manage Afghan migrants' cross-border mobility. These engagements go beyond formalized international agreements, often relying on informal mechanisms such as non-codified procedures, negotiations, diplomatic visits, promises and ad hoc arrangements. It is important to note that the scope of this study is limited to examining the dynamics, drivers and outcomes of the process coercing the return of Afghan migrants from Türkiye to Afghanistan since 2019.⁴

Our research reveals that actors on both sides leverage existing networks and infrastructure to facilitate these returns. The defining characteristics of Türkiye-Afghanistan return diplomacy are embedded in its historical ties, while entanglements of formality and informality shape relations and practices regarding returns without a well-structured institutionalized readmission framework. We argue that several factors trigger the return diplomacy, including the domestic political pressures and geopolitical dynamics pushing the Turkish government to control 'irregular migration' and invest in returns more. Due to power asymmetry in bilateral relations, Türkiye has an advantage over Afghanistan in agenda setting, the capacity to coerce the returns of Afghans and offering small material incentives. The Taliban government seem to accept Turkish authorities' return-related demands due to the historical ties, religio-cultural connections and politico-economic incentives. Additionally, the Taliban's quest for international recognition plays a role in its compliance.

Although the Türkiye-Afghanistan return diplomacy has unique characteristics, the selected returning and returned state pair may still provide some insights for unpacking migration/return diplomacy. It contributes to the scholarship on migration politics by analysing return diplomacy in a South-South context and transit-origin country pairs. Much of the academic and public discourse on return migration and migration diplomacy has focused on agreements between European destination countries and non-European countries. However, interstate bargaining in South-South returns is also increasingly important. For example, transit countries seek to form flexible diplomatic arrangements with origin countries, as observed in Libya, Tunisia and Morocco, to enable coerced returns to Nigeria and sub-Saharan countries (Uzomah et al., 2024). In recent years, Tunisia is actively pursuing agreements with numerous African countries to send back irregular migrants (ANSA, 2024), while Senegal, Mali and Guinea have been collaborating with Morocco since 2021 to identify and repatriate their citizens (Tijani, 2023).

Despite some similarities and relational ties with North-South returns (Fakhoury & Stel, 2023), South-South returns have the potential to reveal nuances for at least three reasons. First, the majority of migrants and refugees move and reside in countries within their immediate region of origin. This means that return migration predominantly takes place within regions experiencing crises. Empirical evidence shows that major refugee-hosting countries in the Global South prefer repatriation as a durable solution, considering local integration and resettlement to third countries as unlikely options. This preference makes large-scale South-South returns more probable, highlighting refugee repatriation as a crucial topic in geopolitics and foreign policy, paving the way for exploring different means of return diplomacy (Fakhoury & Mencütek, 2023; Içduygu & Nimer, 2020; Sahin-Mencutek & Tsourapas, 2023; Mielke, 2023). Second, irregular migration governance and border control in the Global South are not always organized around formal arrangements and regularization. As noted by Koinova (2025, p. 16), 'the geographical terrain of the border can become more or less porous depending on the political and social processes used to govern it at different points of political time'. This is relevant for controlling entries and pushing for the returns of refugees and irregular migrants. Third, both political and socio-spatial aspects of informality, along with the roles of various non-state actors, such as religious and ethnic networks, influence the governance of irregular migration and refugee management, including intra-state bargaining. Migration, including return diplomacy in a

South–South context, often occurs in grey areas. Interestingly, it can lead to continuous collaboration across successive governments that adopt pragmatic and flexible approaches. The paired case of Türkiye and Afghanistan also contributes to discussions on whether there are potential differences between South–South and North–South return dynamics.

The article is organized as follows. It begins with a discussion of the methodology employed in the study. This is followed by exploring the key theoretical and conceptual frameworks, focusing on migration diplomacy and the interplay between formal and informal practices governing return migration. The analysis section is divided into three subsections, addressing the drivers, dynamics and outcomes of return diplomacy. The article concludes by drawing broader insights from the case study to contribute to the theorization of return diplomacy, with particular attention to its relevance in the Global South.

METHODS: DATA COLLECTION, POSITIONALITY AND LIMITATIONS

This article builds on the existing scholarship on migration governance and bilateral relations between two countries. It uses data collected through document review, news, participatory observation and interviews.

A total of 30 semi-structured interviews were conducted with bureaucrats, human rights activists, international and non-governmental organizations, migration experts and grassroots initiatives in Türkiye and Afghanistan as part of two anonymized research projects on return and reintegration (2021 and 2024). Ten semi-structured interviews were conducted in Kabul in February and March 2023 with researchers, experts, a former bureaucrat from the Ministry of Refugees and Repatriation (MoRR), representatives from NGOs engaging in reintegration programmes and a representative of the World Food Programme in collaboration with IDS International. These key informants were asked about the processes and experiences associated with returns from Türkiye, the existing national legal and institutional frameworks governing returns and challenges encountered during and after returns. Moreover, the research involved 12 in-depth interviews and several group discussions with returnees and their families between 19 February and 17 March 2023 in Kabul, Mazar-e Sharif and Daikundi provinces of Afghanistan. Interviews were conducted to understand the real experiences of Afghan returnees, particularly to trace the coercion element in the process. Twenty key informant interviews in Türkiye were conducted in June 2022, January 2023 and April 2024 with asylum lawyers, representatives from international organizations, researchers and NGO representatives. We did not conduct interviews with Afghans in Türkiye but consulted the academic work, shedding light on the conditions and fear of deportations experienced by Afghans (Karadağ & Sert, 2023; Tunaboylu, 2024).

A round-table discussion on Afghanistan's Return and Reintegration policies was held on 9 March 2024 in Kabul, Afghanistan. The panellists included the Acting Director of Policy Planning at the Ministry of Refugees and Repatriation, the Director of Return and Reintegration programmes in the same ministry, two law professors from Kabul University and three researchers from institutes in Kabul. The authors of this paper had a chance to pose questions to the representatives from the ministry about the state of affairs in the bilateral negotiations over returns, policy priorities and concerns of Afghan parties. Additionally, one author made a follow-up visit to the Director of Policy Planning at the Ministry of Refugees and Repatriation to pose additional questions in May 2024. None of these discussions were allowed to be recorded, and names were kept anonymous.

One of the author's prior involvement in several projects as a consultant and participation in over two dozen diplomatic visits concerning the return from Türkiye to Afghanistan has also provided valuable contextual knowledge. The authors' experiences facilitated trust building with key informants, enabling in-depth discussions focusing on return governance processes and unstructured group dialogues with academics, NGOs and diplomats. We acknowledge the complexities of positionality in migration research, where co-ethnic researchers can be 'perceived, viewed, interpreted and positioned as either trusted insiders or auspicious outsiders by study participants' (Tewelde, 2023, p. 30).

While the research incorporates well-grounded contextual knowledge, we sought the verification of every statement and observation from other sources, often via publicly available documents, including media reports published in Türkiye, Afghanistan and elsewhere. News and commentaries from investigative journalism and social media sharing of institutions from both sides provided important insights about the content of diplomatic visits, participating actors, promises and final arrangements. Moreover, for data triangulation, we posed almost the same question to a diverse range of stakeholders, including Turkish authorities, experts, Afghan institutions and Afghan returnees themselves. To mitigate potential bias, we systematically employed both emic and etic perspectives in collecting and analysing the data and critically interpreting information from both formal and informal channels.

Nevertheless, the study had limitations in terms of data collection and actual analysis. First, the political environment in Türkiye and Afghanistan is not entirely conducive to research safety as several topics, including migration politics, are seen as a 'sensitive topic' by state authorities. Second, as elsewhere, bilateral negotiation processes about migration control are not necessarily transparent to the public. Hence, formal cross-checks are pretty difficult. Third, accessing reliable data on informal arrangements between countries is further challenging. As Vigneswaran (2009) highlights, 'the ability to speak confidently about informality in migration governance is limited by a paucity of reliable and comparable data' (p. 2). This lack of data means researchers can only observe certain aspects of these non-formalized relationships. As the topic is very complex and dynamic, arguing for a single driver of relations or making bold arguments while contesting other possible explanations is not feasible.

All the same, studying informal aspects provides valuable insights, as highlighted by Karadağ and Tatar (2024, p. 2), who observe Türkiye's migration authority's secrecy, officials' inaccessibility and the elusive nature of its operational mode; similar challenges are also observable in Afghanistan, often in an even more sensitive manner. Despite these challenges, our research sheds light on facets of informal relations, demonstrating how they coexist with formal policies. While complete data on informal agreements is elusive, interviews with key informants provided insights into their existence and potential influence. For example, similar to Pakistan's approach towards Afghans (Mielke, 2023), scholars studying policies affecting Afghans in Türkiye have noted situations where informality allows for flexibility, such as exploitation in the labour market, while also escalating the fear of deportability as a disciplining apparatus (Karadağ & Sert, 2023; Tunaboylu, 2024). This flexibility, governmentality and 'non-deportability' could be influenced by factors like electoral concerns, surveillance aims and the neoliberal market's need for cheap labour.

In spite of limitations, our explanatory research endeavour seems worthwhile, as it may further promote a de-centring approach (Triandafyllidou, 2022) and address Eurocentrism in migration studies (Fiddian-Qasmiyeh, 2020) by zooming in on informalities and incorporating South–South dynamics into the growing body of literature on return and reintegration as well as migration diplomacy.

THEORETICAL FRAMEWORK: RETURN MIGRATION DIPLOMACY AND 'GREY ZONES'

An expanding wealth of research is emerging about return migration from the perspective of international politics, governance, institutionalism, legal infrastructures, externalization, securitization and development (King & Kuschminder, 2022; Üstübici, 2019). Some studies have focused on the return and reintegration arrangements in origin countries with an emphasis on the impact of the EU's externalization and border control (Marino et al., 2023) or its discourses (Fakhoury & Stel, 2023). However, there is limited information about how governments in the Global South create their policies and programmes for the returns, including the frameworks they use, bargaining, cooperation and readmission agreements. There is not much theorization on how different socio-political, historical and institutional settings influence the development of the host country's plan for repatriating individuals and the home country's processes of readmitting and reintegrating them, except for a few case studies on Pakistan–Afghanistan (Mielke, 2023), Türkiye–Syria (Sahin Mencutek, 2023) and Thailand–Myanmar (Um, 2023). Expanding

the geographical scope to South–South is crucial for a better understanding of return politics and governance, where one can observe different logics due to regime type and the particular identity imbued in governance structures, as well as peculiarities in bilateral relations due to the historical and societal ties.

This article examines how well the concept of migration diplomacy, traditionally applied in Global North–Global South relations, translates to the realities of South–South return migration. While migration diplomacy offers a valuable analytical lens to understand bilateral relations about the returns, it should be further nuanced by examining whether the power dynamics and actors involved differ significantly in this context. Our approach goes beyond formal frameworks by highlighting the role of historical ties and the entanglement of formal and informal practices in shaping the peculiarities of return migration governance. Such an approach will enable a more multifaceted understanding of ‘the heterogeneity of what is often simply referred to as ‘local authorities’ or ‘domestic civil society’ and highlight the tensions and unexpected alliances among local, national and international actors participating in migration governance’ (Gazzotti et al., 2023, p. 625). The following section will commence with an introduction to the concept of migration diplomacy and then move to a discussion of the entanglement of formality and informality in governance structures.

Migration diplomacy

The concept of migration diplomacy has been employed to address the international politics of global migration and mobility (Adamson & Tsourapas, 2019; İçduygu & Üstübcici, 2014; Laube, 2019). It refers to a range of ‘diplomatic tools, processes and procedures to manage cross-border population mobility’ (Tsourapas, 2017). Migration diplomacy can take cooperative or coercive forms. While the former seeks mutually beneficial outcomes, the latter may revert to the threat of force or the unilateral imposition of interstate interests. Both forms are embedded in thematic linkages with other policy areas, such as trade or development (ibid.). The concept has frequently been employed to elucidate how migration has become a pivotal aspect of the negotiation processes and salient debates in EU talks with transit countries, particularly in the context of membership negotiations and their externalization, but fewer in-depth discussions have yet occurred to explore the interplay between migration and interstate bargaining in the Global South (Adamson & Tsourapas, 2020; Mencutek & Tsourapas, 2023). In a seminal study, Tsourapas (2017) provides empirical evidence of the salience of the cooperation and coercion framework by analysing Libya’s migration diplomacy towards its Arab, African and European neighbours under Muammar Gaddafi. Similarly, Laube (2021) posits that externalizing border controls creates new opportunities for migration diplomacy of transit countries such as Moldova, Morocco and Türkiye, which employed mobility regulation as a foreign policy instrument to different degrees.

The research on migration diplomacy provides insight into the historical relationships between countries and the available infrastructure, encompassing the instruments, methods and norms used to facilitate broader context relations. Therefore, these factors should be unpacked to better understand the complexity of migration diplomacy, particularly with regard to the conditions and temporalities under which bilateral relations assume cooperative or coercive forms and how different issues are clustered in bilateral agreements and informal arrangements between states, as well as the involvement of non-state actors.

As returns represent a form of mobility and are increasingly central to negotiation processes among destination, origin and transit countries, the introduction of the concept of return diplomacy is both timely and relevant. This concept, a subcategory of migration diplomacy, refers to a set of negotiations that range from pragmatic, ad hoc arrangements to strategic, long-term collaborations between countries aimed at managing the return of migrants, particularly those categorized as irregular or unauthorized. The process is characterized by flexible diplomatic arrangements that integrate return policies into broader foreign policy agendas, including areas such as economic development cooperation, security and other bilateral priorities. It is possible to hypothesize that historical ties, overarching interests and expectations, incentives and power politics

inevitably affect the key dynamics of return diplomacy, such as who sets the agenda (e.g. origin and destination countries), how the conduct of this diplomacy operates (e.g. the utilization of soft power, public diplomacy or blackmailing) and what type of relations (e.g. formal, informal, reciprocal) and outcomes (e.g. deals, formal agreements) appear. Zooming on all these dynamics indicates the significance of informal institutions, networks and relations alongside formal ones. So, the entanglement of formality and informality can contribute to a deeper discussion on migration diplomacy, particularly regarding bilateral bargaining about returns. This entanglement will be discussed below.

Entanglement of formality and informality in governance and return diplomacy

One exciting line of research examines the dialectical relationship between formality and informality (Scott, 1998) and focuses on grey zones in policymaking (Knudsen & Frederiksen, 2015). The informal practices are not necessarily exceptions or deviations from a norm (Ledeneva, 2013). Instead, they may appear to be a crucial aspect of migration governance. Informality 'fills the void of missing policies or challenging explicit rules' (Koinova, 2022, p. 18), or it supplements formal rules or circumvents established rules on multiple levels of complexity. It manifests differently in each grey zone, where one can observe a complex interplay between formal and informal political authority. In the governance literature, this situation is identified as 'hybrid orders/governance' (Boege et al., 2009; Meagher, 2012), 'politics of indifference' (Norman, 2019) or 'strategic ambiguity' (Stel, 2021), especially under conditions structured by 'limited statehood' (Risse, 2011).

The entanglement of formality and informality is not a recent phenomenon in migration management. In fact, it has long been a central modality of bilateral and multilateral relations between states. Informal channels of diplomacy are those means of communication and negotiation between states outside formal diplomatic channels such as embassies, official meetings, negotiations and agreements. Informal channels are used as a primary communication method in certain circumstances, such as a lack of formal communication channels and procedures. Diplomats, state leaders, civil society organizations (CSOs) and quite often think tanks use private, unofficial, non-government communication methods to build on mutual trust as well as informal meetings and negotiations to discuss 'sensitive' political issues to prepare the conditions of a formal agreement or to start formal diplomatic talks (Diamond & McDonald, 1996). Faith-based diplomacy (Thomas, 2017; Troy, 2008) is also a form of this unofficial diplomacy that integrates religious networks, which often have a transnational character, constituting a social foundation for building and maintaining relations, particularly in the context of conflict resolution (Thomas, 2017) or the ideational/religious background of diplomacy actors (Stempel, 2000).

The interplay of formal and informal dynamics and mechanisms is inherent to migration diplomacy. When destination countries negotiate with origin, transit or fourth countries, they often bypass formal procedures, opting instead for informal, pragmatic engagements with a range of actors. This approach is typically aimed at curbing migration flows or facilitating the return of rejected asylum seekers and 'irregular' migrants (Cassarino, 2017; Trauner, 2018; Wolff, 2014). Cardwell and Dickson (2023) have coined the term 'formal informality' to describe the 'mobility partnerships between the EU and third countries as a means of informal governance in the context of external migration' (p. 3121). This insight is vital because many of these partnerships have been less forthcoming in terms of mobility to the EU, yet more focused on mechanisms for returns and readmission of migrants.

As many bilateral and multilateral discussions, negotiations and arrangements within migration diplomacy increasingly centre on return and readmission issues, these processes can be categorized under the broader concept of return diplomacy. The interplay between formal and informal mechanisms is particularly significant in this context, as return diplomacy often depends on unofficial channels and the practice of 'formal informality' for two key reasons. First, return arrangements on the negotiation table are highly pragmatic and contain 'open secrets' (Ledeneva, 2013) that are not fully communicated publicly. Therefore, the details of these negotiations and even the agreements achieved are not fully transparent. Second, inherent ambiguity is a defining characteristic of both

the process and its outcomes, as it allows each political entity the flexibility to renegotiate agreements or abandon them entirely when such arrangements no longer serve their interests.

Although the interplay between formal and informal channels in return diplomacy has been predominantly examined within the European Union in relation to transit and origin countries, there is a paucity of studies that have investigated South–South dynamics (Mielke, 2023). This paper aims to bridge this gap by offering a detailed case study of Türkiye and Afghanistan. It examines how formal and informal relations are intertwined and how these dynamics may have shifted over time and shaped return diplomacy, particularly following the Taliban takeover in Afghanistan. To contextualize return diplomacy and governance in this paired case, we will in the following section delve into the historical and contemporary relations and networks that connect, both formally and informally, highlighting the actors involved in these flows and connections.

THE DRIVERS OF RETURN DIPLOMACY: HISTORICAL RELATIONS AND MUTUAL INTERESTS

Türkiye and Afghanistan share deep-rooted social, cultural and political ties that have evolved across different periods. Their relationship, historically marked by amity, predates the formation of the modern Turkish state. Afghan politicians and intellectuals drew inspiration from the Ottoman Empire's modernization efforts in administration, education and law from 1908 to 1923 (Siddikoğlu, 2020, p. 215). These enduring partnerships have been nurtured through formal diplomatic and informal personal connections. In the context of diplomatic friendship, Türkiye took the initiative of providing support to Afghanistan in the areas of infrastructure and governance and signed a number of cooperation agreements with the country (Bishku, 2020, p. 241; Rasanayagam, 2000). Türkiye sponsored an administrative school to train Afghan civil servants, played a pivotal role in drafting Afghanistan's 1923 constitution and provided training for the Afghan military (O'Sullivan, 2016, p. 1850).

The paradigm shifts in the balance of power in the post-World War entirely changed the political milieu of Afghanistan, in a way, a departure from Afghanistan's previous nonalignment policy (Rasanayagam, 2000, p. 34). Despite having religio-cultural ties with some Afghan state and non-state actors, Türkiye's engagements in Afghanistan during the Cold War period remained limited. With the Soviet invasion in 1979, Afghanistan plunged into protracted warfare, forcing millions to be displaced within and outside the country. In March 1982, Türkiye passed a settlement law (No. 2641) to resettle Afghan ethnic groups of Turkish lineages, such as Uzbeks, Turkmens, Kazakhs and Kyrgyz (Şimşek, 2021). Around 4163 Afghan refugees were resettled from Pakistan to Türkiye (Ibid). Since then, many Afghans have migrated to Türkiye to seek protection, work, study or to transit to Europe.

Following the US-led intervention in Afghanistan, Turkey's engagement in the country underwent a notable transformation, particularly following the deployment of the NATO-led International Security Assistance Force (ISAF) in December 2001. Türkiye led the force (2002–2003 and 2005) and actively contributed to the training and equipping of Afghan security forces and providing logistical support (Bishku, 2020, p. 250). Türkiye's foreign policy has undergone significant transformation since 2000, particularly following the rise to power of the Justice and Development Party (Adalet ve Kalkınma Partisi, AKP) in 2002. The robust economic growth experienced between 1999 and 2010 played a crucial role in enhancing Türkiye's soft power, which extended its influence to Afghanistan and beyond (Karlı, 2009, p. 119). The AKP has influenced the geopolitical landscape, mainly using mediation endeavours, humanitarian diplomacy and the concept of cultural and historical closeness (Altunisik, 2023; Bishku, 2020). AKP politicians were confident that they were acquainted with adequate networks available with the religious groups, as the ideological ties made available new resources and opportunities by circumventing traditional foreign policymakers such as diplomats (Dinçer, 2022). All these factors have positioned Türkiye prominently in the Muslim world, especially among Afghan elites, certain religious networks and the public, as repeatedly recalled in our interviews.

The ideational basis of AKP, conceiving Türkiye as the holder of a compassionate identity in the Islamic world, was reflected in legitimizing Türkiye's presence in Afghanistan and its quest as a mediator by using the Islamic terminology around brotherhood among Muslims (Altunisik, 2023, p. 9). The importance of the long history of ties and cultural similarities was frequently emphasized by the Afghan high-level ministerial bureaucrats we interviewed. Religious and cultural affinities became pivotal as robust soft power elements that nurtured bilateral relationships and bolstered partnerships extending to migration issues.

Economic and development cooperation is also prominent in bilateral relations, preparing the ground for strengthened collaboration on migration. Turkish enterprises participated in hundreds of projects, and bilateral trade volumes increased for years (Bishku, 2020; OEC, 2024). The Turkish Cooperation and Coordination Agency (TIKA), established in 1992 to develop collaborative ties with the Turkic Central Asian states, has played a prominent role in providing development assistance in the education, health and infrastructure sectors (Güzeldere, 2022). TIKA has sponsored several reconstruction projects, creating a positive image among Afghan government leaders, the public and the Taliban regime (Sahin-Mencutek, 2022). In 2019, Afghanistan received the fifth-largest allocation of Turkish development aid channelled by TIKA following Syria, Bosnia Herzegovina, Palestine and Iraq (TIKA, 2019, 31). In the last decade, TIKA has sponsored 1300 projects in Afghanistan, mostly in education, health, emergency aid support and infrastructure restoration (TIKA, 2019). Besides delivering food and non-food humanitarian assistance, TIKA has also initiated projects to expand livelihood opportunities and vocational training to benefit Afghans, including displaced persons and returnees, according to media reports and an expert interviewed (Sahin-Mencutek, 2022). Since 2018, Türkiye has sponsored formally dozens of educational institutions and education centres in Afghanistan, which provide university preparation, Turkish, foreign language, culture and art education.⁵

Migration control has been a prominent aspect of Turkey's bilateral relations with Afghanistan. Afghan migrants constituted the largest officially designated irregular migrant population in Türkiye between 2014 and 2024, although their exact numbers remain uncertain. The Turkish government has increasingly emphasized the coercion of returns as a central strategy in managing irregular migration. Since the early 1980s, Türkiye has served as both a transit and destination country for Afghan migrants. However, unlike asylum seekers from European countries, Afghan migrants are not granted official refugee status due to Turkey's geographical limitation under the Geneva Refugee Convention. A considerable number of Afghan migrants have entered Türkiye by means of irregular border crossings without being registered and thus are unable to apply for any protection status. For instance, in the period between January and May of 2024, a total of 74,032 migrants were apprehended, 24,455 of whom were Afghans (Göçgov, 2024). Apprehension data from previous years also suggest high numbers of 'irregular' Afghans apprehended; for example, 68,687 in 2023 and 225,775 in 2022.⁶ For coercing the return of these apprehended Afghans, it is evident that coordination with the relevant authorities in Afghanistan is essential and that the continuation of diplomatic relations with those in power there is vital. When the Taliban assumed control, the possibility of a swift return of Afghan migrants was still a key priority, given the significant numbers of Afghans held in prolonged detention in Turkey and apprehended at border crossings.

It is crucial to ascertain the underlying causes that have led Türkiye to prioritize the issue of returns and to maintain return diplomacy with the Taliban. The Turkish government has been confronted with domestic pressure and public unease regarding the significant presence of refugees and irregular migrants, as well as the deportation stance espoused by political parties. Furthermore, in its relations with the EU, since 2016, Türkiye has been expected to reduce the number of irregular migrants, including Afghans, attempting to reach European shores and Europe provides financial and capacity-building support for border controls. Türkiye has demonstrated a willingness to maintain both formal and informal communication channels with the Taliban government. This stance is consistent with its overarching geopolitical and ideational interests, as well as concerns about managing the migration of Afghan nationals to Türkiye. Following the Taliban's return to power in August 2021, Türkiye has continued to prioritize tangible forms of cooperation.

On the other side, facing a fragile socio-economic and political situation and lacking full recognition, the Taliban exercises *de facto* authority and has established diplomatic relations with a limited number of countries, including Türkiye. The authors observed in policy workshops and bilateral exchanges that the Taliban perceives Türkiye as a potentially pivotal and constructive partner in Afghanistan's reconstruction. This conviction is reinforced by the shared interests of both states and their common religious heritage, which prompts the Taliban to seek Türkiye's backing for its international legitimacy.

DYNAMICS: ACTORS AND ENGAGEMENTS

Although there was no formal readmission agreement between the two countries, some arrangements are in place. Before 2021, Türkiye and Afghanistan had been engaged in developing a draft readmission agreement in collaboration with the International Centre for Migration Policy Development (ICMPD), a European intergovernmental organization with observer status at the UN. Also, the Turkish branch of the IOM used to provide AVRR programmes to Afghans who requested 'voluntary return' after being apprehended trying to exit illegally to Greece. Previously, some 2344 Afghans benefited from this programme (EC, 2020, p. 48). However, according to our interview with one policy officer in Türkiye in 2022, the IOM programme was 'smaller in scale than Türkiye's needs, slow and expensive considering the huge number of irregular migrants'. The Turkish Ministry of the Interior, law enforcement agencies and the Presidency of Migration Management are responsible for apprehending and detaining Afghans. Not all detentions resulted in actual returns. Instead, some were released (due to capacity issues) after being given a removal order.

In order to facilitate the return of Afghans, the Turkish authorities have employed a range of channels. It has been reported in the Turkish media that high-level bilateral visits have been conducted on an *ad hoc* basis, including visits by Afghan officials to the eastern cities of Türkiye in close proximity to the border with Iran, where a significant number of Afghans were deported. For example, in 2018, Turkish and Afghan officials agreed to provide travel documents to 670 Afghans detained in Erzurum's removal centres and sent back via charter flights, according to local Turkish media (Karar, 2018). In interviews conducted with key informants in Afghanistan, it was revealed that flights facilitated the return of thousands of Afghans to Kabul. Concurrently, the Afghan government of the time appointed an attaché to Ankara with the objective of facilitating the documentation required for prospective Afghans to travel. At that time, the Afghan media reported that Afghan officials refuted reports from Amnesty International, which alleged that individuals had been forcibly returned from Türkiye (Pajhwok, 2018). In the past, Turkish authorities engaged in bilateral coordination with diplomatic missions of Afghanistan in Türkiye. In particular, the Embassy of Afghanistan in Ankara and the General Consulate of Afghanistan in Istanbul are responsible for the issuance of travel documents. Subsequently, communication is initiated with the Afghan Ministry of Foreign Affairs and the Ministry of Migration and Repatriation with the objective of facilitating the readmission of the individual in question.

Meanwhile, the Presidency of Migration Management established a National Assisted Voluntary Return Mechanism (NAVR) (EC, 2020, p. 47). Türkiye's foreign aid and development agency, TİKA and the Turkish Red Crescent were also involved in the NAVR initiative, which gained momentum in 2021 when supporting regulations were enacted. ICMPD provided technical and funding support on a project basis (2021–2023) in areas like training Turkish return counsellors (ICMPD, 2024). The experts we consulted asserted that Turkish and Afghan diplomats maintain that Turkish governmental organizations, such as TİKA, indirectly facilitate the process of readmission negotiations and potentially collaborate in coordinating the implementation of return operations and mutual re-integration initiatives at the governmental level. The NAVR scheme was tested with the 'voluntary' return of 41 Afghans in April 2021.

Amid Türkiye's effort to maintain its NAVR and increase returns to Afghanistan, regime change occurred in Afghanistan with the Taliban's ascension to power in the summer of 2021. This transition resulted in a significant

reduction in the number of diplomatic missions operating in the region, as well as the suspension of return operations by IOM and other countries. In contrast, Türkiye opted to maintain its diplomatic representation. Subsequently, the Turkish government has not formally recognized the interim Taliban government through the establishment of diplomatic relations. However, it has engaged in relations with the Taliban. As early as coming to power, the Taliban government signalled that it was eager to continue diplomatic relations with Türkiye, while Türkiye also wanted to maintain its active role after the US withdrawal, such as being in charge of securing Kabul airport and aspired to take a mediator role in the Taliban's relations with the outside world (Basit & Ahmed, 2021; Hurriyet Daily, 2021). Turkish state institutions and networks have been engaged in the ongoing endeavour of maintaining their aid activities while exercising the requisite caution. According to one of the authors' discussions with diplomats in Kabul, Turkish missions in Mazar-e Sharif, Herat and Kabul have played a significant role in engaging with the Taliban government to ensure the smooth implementation of Turkish humanitarian aid. The engagements also include the provision of educational activities in Afghanistan facilitated by the Turkish government-controlled Maarif Foundation.⁷ AFAD, Kızılay and TİKA have continued to provide emergency assistance to vulnerable populations across Afghanistan. According to the observations and exchanges of the authors in Afghanistan, most development projects are currently on hold. TİKA primarily provides life-saving assistance, such as food and non-food emergency aid. Turkish businesspeople who work in the construction sector have continued their businesses despite bureaucratic slowdowns (Haberturktv, 2022).

At the same time, the Taliban government has maintained existing policy frameworks and strategic agreements, indicating continuity in diplomatic policy. In interviews with Afghan ministry representatives and experts, it was asserted that the Taliban's caretaker government represents a continuation of the former political institution. In a roundtable discussion held in March 2024, the high-level bureaucrats from the MoRR emphasized that the Taliban government is committed to the Refugee Convention. Insights from interviewees pointed out that the main challenge lies in the Taliban's lack of international recognition, which limits the ability of other nations to engage with Taliban officials under existing bilateral or international agreements. Nevertheless, as a policy analyst working on Afghan and Türkiye relations noted, there are some distinct differences in diplomacy, the manner of dialogue, communication modalities, negotiation dynamics and bargaining tactics (Güzeldere, 2022).

Within this dynamic context, numerous official meetings have taken place at different levels involving both countries' ministries of Foreign Affairs, discussions between migration authorities, the Turkish ambassadors and the Acting Minister of MoRR (Tolo News, 2023). Türkiye's early offer to operate Kabul airport on behalf of the Taliban authorities in the summer of 2021 (Sabah, 2022) raised concerns among experts interviewed for this research about the looming resumption of Afghan deportations. Although the Taliban declined Türkiye's bid, deportations continue in growing numbers. In April 2022, Turkish media reported about the resumed return flights, which carried 908 'irregular migrants' to Afghanistan (Haberturktv, 2022). According to interviews, Afghan National Airlines (Ariana International Airlines) and privately owned charter airlines took part, in addition to Turkish Airlines. Upon return, Afghans are registered with the help of international organizations and other stakeholders in the country.

Additionally, as reported by Turkish media outlets,⁸ the Türkiye-based transnational religious networks, such as the Ismailaga Brotherhood,⁹ are known to engage with representatives of the Taliban, which was also noted in the key informant interviews in Afghanistan. The Ismailaga Brotherhood is a religious network (community) based in Istanbul, Türkiye, aligned with the Naqshbandi order, which is the most widespread Sufi brotherhood in the world. There is a considerable body of scholarly literature and media commentary (Cornell & Kaya, 2015; Erturk, 2022) suggesting a close relationship between the Naqshbandi Ismailaga community and the Turkish governing actors. The network maintains strict adherence to religious law and is actively involved in social and political affairs in Türkiye. According to Afghan media outlets, there have been several discussions between Turkish religious figures and Afghanistan's MoRR concerning migration-related issues (Tolo News, 2023).

Besides formal engagements, informal and ad hoc diplomatic channels are also in place for keeping returned Afghans in Afghanistan and halting (re)migration to Türkiye.¹⁰ There are expectations from Afghan

authorities for getting support in reintegration and reconstruction. In a personal informal communication with a high-level bureaucrat at the MoRR, he emphasized that reintegration is a fundamental aspect of return migration governance and that the Afghan government requires both institutional and financial assistance from the international community and host countries, including Türkiye. Formally, Turkish TİKA and Turkish Red Crescent have some aid programs benefiting the returnees. Besides them, according to Turkish media, networks such as the Ismailaga Brotherhood are known for their established relations with the leadership of the Taliban (Bugün Kıbrıs, 2023). For example, in the diplomatic tour of the Taliban in October 2023, the Foreign Affairs minister visited the Ismailaga Brotherhood's mosque in Istanbul. Just a month after that, the brotherhood's representatives met with the Afghan Ministry of Interior in Kabul during a reciprocal visit in 2023. The increasing engagement with faith groups raised questions in Turkish media about 'whether diplomatic relations between two countries are run by the Ismailaga group'. Moreover, the NGO affiliated with the Ismailaga Brotherhood dealing with external affairs, IDDEF, started to establish educational and recreational facilities in Afghanistan.

This strategic use of non-formal or hybrid relations¹¹ may not have a direct impact on dynamics related to return migration. Nevertheless, the involvement of non-state actors in promoting social services – such as establishing schools and providing humanitarian aid to vulnerable groups, including returnees – aimed to facilitate their reintegration. This effort is particularly significant given the absence of legal and policy frameworks to support the socio-economic and property rights of returnees, as highlighted in the returnee interviews.

Also, in a group discussion conducted with high-level officials from the Afghan migration agencies in March 2024, they stated that the Turkish government has been on all fronts supportive of the Interim Government of Afghanistan, the Taliban. In a discussion between the authors and a Turkish diplomat in Kabul, it emerged that the Taliban leadership has called upon Türkiye to act as the 'elder sibling' and take measures extending beyond the mere deportation of Afghans. These measures include providing shelter to Afghan migrants in Türkiye and assisting with their reintegration process. Several interviewees observed that Afghan migration agencies lack the requisite capacity to institutionalize mass returns and reintegration processes within the country.

OUTCOMES OF BILATERAL RETURN COOPERATION FOR AFGHAN MIGRANTS

Despite the aforementioned diplomatic engagements, a transparent formal readmission agreement between Türkiye and Afghanistan has yet to be reached. Notwithstanding the remarks of certain Afghan experts who have suggested that the Taliban-led government may be disinclined to sign formal readmission agreements with Türkiye, other interviews have indicated that 'one can speculate that certain agreements have been signed on return between Afghanistan and some countries'. As a representative from an organization providing humanitarian assistance to returnees in Afghanistan has noted, the lack of media coverage surrounding these agreements makes it difficult to confirm details.

Nevertheless, existing return infrastructures and channels are reportedly being used intensively to coerce Afghans' return from Türkiye. One interviewed practitioner working for reintegration of returnees in Afghanistan said that 'there has been a considerable number of returnees from Türkiye in the last two years' by adding that 'return is not their choice; all are coerced. Migrants are usually provided with two choices: prison or return, and within this context, they prefer to sign a [voluntary return] document for their freedom'. Another interviewed practitioner said that 'the majority of the returnees are coerced and forced to return. They do not have a choice in their return from Türkiye'. Many wait for opportunities for onward migration to Europe. On the journey, they become the subject to restrictive border controls, including push/pullbacks on the Türkiye-Iran, Greece or Bulgaria border points, as well as surveillance and detention on the grounds of irregular entry, exit and stay in Türkiye (Karadağ & Sert, 2023).

Furthermore, the interviews conducted with Afghan returnees revealed a troubling pattern of coerced returns. They recounted how they had been subjected to pushbacks at the border between Türkiye and Iran, had been detained in camps with harsh conditions and pressured to sign 'voluntary return' documents without having been provided with an adequate explanation or having been afforded the opportunity to submit asylum applications when apprehended. These findings indicate that a significant number of Afghans have been subjected to a range of formal and informal tactics designed to coerce their return from Türkiye.

Due to power asymmetry in bilateral relations, Türkiye is in a position to coerce the returns of Afghan citizens and offer them some material incentives¹² and support for development cooperation. In contrast, the Taliban is in a relatively weaker position and demonstrates a certain degree of compliance, although not direct contestation. From informal conversations, it can be observed that the Taliban government representatives are avoiding direct criticism of Türkiye despite its practice of coercing Afghan citizens to return. A review of Afghan media sources indicates that there has been no criticism directed at Pakistan and Iran for the coerced returns of Afghans. This reticence likely reflects a strategic prioritization of securing international aid for returnees and aligning with the UNHCR's call to separate political issues from migration (ANSA, 2024). However, as reported in the Afghan media, the Taliban have initiated diplomatic efforts to advocate for their position on the issue, including a tour of neighbouring countries in 2023, which included Türkiye. While they have not demanded an end to deportations, they have called for more humane practices and alternative pathways, such as offering employment opportunities to Afghan refugees instead of returning them to Afghanistan (Tolo News, 2023). In engagements with Turkish officials, such as in October 2023, Afghan diplomats highlighted that Afghan migrants are currently facing escalating challenges, discrimination, harassment and violence in their workplaces and during their arrests, and these officials demanded urgent attention to these issues (Tolo News, 2023). The Taliban government has observed that many Afghans in Türkiye lack adequate protection, leaving them vulnerable to various forms of abuse (Radio Azadi, 2023), including sexual violence during migration crossings – a matter that has incited widespread anger among both the Afghan public and government officials (Rahmati, 2023). During their visit, the Afghan delegation inspected several detention centres and expressed dissatisfaction with the conditions experienced by Afghan returnees in Türkiye. Furthermore, according to an interview with Afghan ministry bureaucrats, a joint technical team was established to oversee the return and reintegration of Afghan migrants. This team, comprising representatives from line ministries in both countries, is tasked with managing the operational modalities of the NAVR programme and ensuring a structured approach to return and reintegration processes.

CONCLUSION: UNVEILING SOUTH-SOUTH RETURN DIPLOMACY THROUGH THE LENS OF TÜRKİYE- AFGHANISTAN RELATIONS

The threads of drivers, dynamics and outcomes of return diplomacy, as well as intricacies among them, can be summarized as follows. Regarding the drivers, the domestic political pressures (anti-migrant and pro-deportation public sentiment and polarization of the political landscape around the migration issue) and geopolitical dynamics regarding its relations with the EU and its wider goals of becoming a regional playmaker and representative of the *Muslim world* are all factors that must be taken into account when contextualizing Türkiye's goals and motivations on the table. The necessity for coordination in facilitating Afghan returns provides an incentive for Türkiye to engage with the Taliban government despite the absence of formal recognition. Conversely, the Taliban is pursuing international legitimacy and aims to consolidate its domestic power by presenting itself as the protector and caretaker of returnee Afghans. This engagement situates the Taliban within the informal zone of power, whereas Türkiye occupies a position of formal authority and legitimacy, affording it a more advantageous and superior status in relations. Türkiye's established position in the international community, compared to the Taliban's unrecognized status, creates a dynamic for informality, which potentially grants some legitimacy to the Taliban regime through engagement with Türkiye. It is also important

to note that the Taliban's cooperation around return operations could be seen as a calculated move. They might aim to gain some international legitimacy through engagement with Türkiye while also providing control over migration flows and potential influence on regional security, which could also be seen as bargaining chips in their interactions with Türkiye.

Regarding dynamics, this complex situation highlights the use of both formal and informal diplomacy. The absence of a formal agreement gives rise to concerns, yet the continuation of engagement between the parties involved suggests a pragmatic approach. However, this approach has resulted in a number of troubling outcomes, including the forced return of thousands of individuals without adequate monitoring and transparency, which has violated their human and asylum rights. As return diplomacy between Türkiye and Afghanistan takes place in a specific context, it shapes the policy repertoires, tools, channels and the interplay between formality and informality in diplomatic relations. Interconnectedness is not an isolated occurrence; rather, it emerges from historical experiences, common cultural values and transnational networks linking elites on both sides. These shared experiences heavily influence how both political entities view and address international affairs, security issues and their broader surroundings, including migration. Nevertheless, the actors' geopolitical position, resources and power asymmetries are important factors for understanding countries' bargaining power in return migration diplomacy, according to the outcomes at policy and operational levels. Besides Türkiye, Afghan authorities have held a negotiating power as well. As outlined in the article, at least three factors have significantly contributed to the Taliban government accepting return migration pressure: historical ties, religio-cultural connections and potential politico-economic incentives such as international recognition and development aid. Hence, both Türkiye and Afghanistan have several interests in using diplomatic tools and procedures, including a significant amount of non-codified arrangements and negotiations, to manage cross-border population mobility, which is also unique in the Global South as the two countries do not share a physical border.

Despite being non-generalizable, the specific case pair has provided valuable insights into migration politics, going beyond the traditional Global North–South divide and highlighting unique characteristics of return migration governance and bilateral negotiations in the Global South. It has also expanded the field of migration diplomacy by introducing the concept of return diplomacy, shedding light on how countries negotiate and manage return processes in the Global South. This research has emphasized the intricate interplay between formal and informal agreements, the use of various diplomatic strategies and their connection to other policy areas such as trade and development. Additionally, the findings emphasize that power imbalances play a central role in migration diplomacy, albeit in different ways depending on the context and time period.

Furthermore, the study has shown that a distinctive aspect of South–South return dynamics is the notion of continuity in diplomatic relations and infrastructures. As highlighted in this paper, the relations between Türkiye and Afghanistan, despite the Taliban's takeover, continued to be built upon more or less the same and similar diplomacy channels and methods. In this regard, historical and cultural ties and networks are important factors that need to be taken into account for analysing return diplomacy. This finding urges us to think about continuity in governance modes, defining the trajectories of diplomatic relations involving both formal and informal ones. Whereas the relations between the Global North and Global South for facilitating return and readmissions are characterized by ruptures or more rigid political turns which may lead to the discontinuity of earlier political agreements and informal arrangements.

Without having a normative bias and oversimplification as 'north/formality' versus 'south/informality', findings suggest a continuum between formality and informality. Though informal arrangements are common in South–South relations, this aspect does not necessarily make them 'illegitimate'. Contrarily, those practices and arrangements perceived as informal are implicit in policymaking everywhere. Their lack of formalization should be explicitly studied in each context. Therefore, as we showed in this article, both negotiating sides deliberately kept their relations in the informal zone in order to leverage certain policy outcomes. The informal aura in the relations provided them with flexibility, efficiency in policy implementation and room to manoeuvre when facing criticism.

The paper suggests looking at blended, hybrid approaches in migration diplomacy where both formal (e.g. ministerial meetings) and informal channels (NGOs, faith-based networks or informal talks and meetings) are crucial for facilitating dialogue and agreements. The selected case illustrates that further theorizing the governance of South–South returns requires a closer look at not only actors but also relations and processes. Negotiating parties in migration diplomacy tend to rely on their old networks to address new issues like return and reintegration. One relevant question is why states prefer informal talks and legally less-binding agreements and arrangements on migration, including returns. One plausible explanation is the sensitivity of the topic, which actors may perceive as a hindrance to making unconstrained deliberations. Consequently, we observe pragmatic moves and trade-like negotiations in migration and readmission deals. Here, informality is deployed instrumentally to escape from the potential 'burden' and 'complexity' of formal structures or formal ways of doing things. From this perspective, existing formal approaches to migration are one of the reasons for policy deadlock. Hence, going informal becomes a way of getting things done by passing certain procedures and principles.

As discussed earlier in this article, migration governance is witnessing a notable shift towards informal methods, which raises significant concerns about its consequences regarding the protection of human rights and the long-term viability of migration policies. This growing reliance on informality is often justified under the guise of 'efficiency', wherein formal procedures, negotiations and agreements are perceived as insufficient to address pressing challenges. States increasingly employ informal practices to enhance policy flexibility and avoid scrutiny of their coercive interstate bargaining, a trend not limited to Europe but evident in other regions as well. However, bypassing formal legal frameworks, such as the principles of voluntariness in returns and non-refoulement, risks eroding transparency and compromising the protection of human and asylum rights for Afghans and other migrants. The EU's approach, which positions Türkiye as a buffer zone to deter Afghan migration into Europe through financial incentives, fails to offer a sustainable solution. Instead, it forces migrants onto dangerous clandestine routes and enables Türkiye to leverage migration as a strategic tool in its relations with the EU. As informal approaches tend to offer short-term solutions and operational flexibility, they often undermine transparency and accountability. Furthermore, the growing informality in migration governance can exacerbate the challenges faced by returning migrants, particularly in countries like Afghanistan, where reconstruction efforts are still ongoing. The lack of formal channels and transparent processes can hinder adequate support and protection for these vulnerable populations.

To mitigate these risks, policymakers must prioritize transparency and accountability in diplomatic engagements and migration policy designs. It is crucial to balance the need for efficient migration management with the ethical imperative to safeguard the rights of migrants in bilateral talks that directly or indirectly involve migration issues. By strengthening international cooperation, promoting legal pathways for migration and addressing the root causes of migration while investing in long-term sustainable development in countries of origin, policymakers can create a more humane and effective approach to migration governance.

FUNDING INFORMATION

This paper was produced as part of the Horizon Europe project 'GAPS: De-centring the Study of Migrant Returns and Readmission Policies in Europe and Beyond' (grant number: 101094341).

CONFLICT OF INTEREST STATEMENT

There is no conflict of interest.

PEER REVIEW

The peer review history for this article is available at <https://www.webofscience.com/api/gateway/wos/peer-review/10.1111/imig.70037>.

DATA AVAILABILITY STATEMENT

Research data are not shared.

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Endnotes

- ¹The terms 'return' 'repatriation' 'deportation' are used interchangeably in this article.
- ²The terms 'return', 'repatriation', 'deportation' and 'removal' are used interchangeably throughout the text. Given that an element of coercion is intrinsic to the enforcement of these measures, we adopt the umbrella term 'coerced returns' to describe the process (see Sahin-Mencutek & Triandoffidou, 2025). For a debate on categorical complexity in return migration, see Sahin-Mencutek (2024).
- ³Our focus is not on IOM-assisted returns, which are quite limited in number, but instead on Türkiye's own arrangements with Afghan authorities, resulting in the returns of thousands of Afghans via hundreds of flights.
- ⁴Similar to other scholarly work, we see Afghans in Türkiye as 'irregularized humanitarian migrants', because many 'left their country of citizenship in hopes of finding protection abroad but do not, or no longer, hold a permanent legal status' (van Houte et al., 2023, p. 315). Throughout the text, for the sake of brevity, we will use the term of Afghan migrants and Afghans interchangeably, except when we directly cite from Turkish official statistics and media identifying Afghan irregular migrants as a policy category.
- ⁵For information, visit Afghan-Türk Maarif Schools official website at <https://www.afganturkmaarif.org/Home/en#:~:text=Afghan%2DTurk%20Maarif%20Schools%20are,in%207%20provinces%20across%20Afghanistan>.
- ⁶The number of Afghans apprehended in 2023 was 68,687, a figure that increased to 225,775 in 2022, 70,737 in 2021, 50,161 in 2020, 201,437 in 2019, 100,841 in 2018, 45,259 in 2017, 31,160 in 2016, 35,921 in 2015 and 12,428 in 2014. <https://www.goc.gov.tr/duzensiz-goc-istatistikler>. Statistics updated 02 May 2024. Accessed 12 May 2024.
- ⁷Maarif Foundation 2024, Afghan-Türk Maarif Schools <https://www.afganturkmaarif.org/home/tr>.
- ⁸<https://haber.sol.org.tr/haber/ismailaga-cemaatinden-taliban-ziyareti-afganistana-gittiler-388382>; <https://www.ateizmdernegi.org.tr/blog/2024/01/23/ismailaga-cemaati-talibanla-kucak-kucaga/>. <https://yurtsever.org.tr/2023/ismailagacilar-talibanla-diplomatik-gorushmeler-yaptigini-acikladi-522398/>.
- ⁹This is a religious network (community) based in Istanbul, Türkiye, aligned with the Naqshbandi order, which is the most widespread Sufi brotherhood in the world. It is widely reported (said that) in the scholarly work and media that there is a close relationship between the Naqshbandi İsmailaga community and the Turkish governing party, the AKP and ministries. The network has a strict adherence to religious law and active involvement in social and political affairs in Türkiye. (see Aviv, 2018; Hamsici, 2019).
- ¹⁰See <https://serbestiyet.com/featured/afghanistan-disisleri-bakani-ismailagayi-ziyaret-etti-146795/>; <https://www.cumhuriyet.com.tr/Türkiye/ismailagadan-talibana-ziyaret-2127058>; and <https://sputniknews.com.tr/20221028/ismailagadan-talibana-ziyaret-medrese-acilisi-yaptilar-1062821205.html>.
- ¹¹https://www.cumhuriyet.com.tr/Türkiye/taliban-diplomasisi-ismailaga-cemaati-son-donemde-afghanistan-2156509#google_vignette.
- ¹²Returnees whom we interviewed reported that 30 USD was paid to each Afghan after they consented to return in the deportations that occurred in 2022 and 2023.

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How to cite this article: Sahin-Mencutek, Z., Siddikoğlu, H. & Barthoma, S. (2025) Return governance and diplomacy between Türkiye and Afghanistan. *International Migration*, 63, e70037. Available from: <https://doi.org/10.1111/imig.70037>